

MERIDIAN  CLASSIC

WILLIAM FAULKNER SARTORIS





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FICTION

SARTORIS WILLIAM FAULKNER

The specter of a heroic past is ever present in *Sartoris*, casting its ironic light upon the novel's protagonists. Heirs to the aristocratic traditions of the Old South, they have been left with only romantic rhetoric, pride, and self-pity to face a world that no longer mirrors their self-image. Bayard Sartoris seeks refuge in compulsive acts of physical courage; Horace Benbow, in a bloodless aestheticism; and Narcissa Benbow, in a desperate clinging to appearances. But for them there is to be no escape—only ultimate futility, whether in the form of violent self-destruction, or a living death in a fragile world of dreams. A brilliant dissection of a decaying social class, and a vivid evocation of both the physical landscape and psychological climate of the South, *Sartoris* introduces many of the key themes, places, and characters of the Faulkner canon. By itself, it stands as his first memorable projection of a vision that, as Lawrance Thompson writes, "recognizes the inseparability of human weaknesses and strengths, of positives and negatives, of good and evil... what Faulkner later called 'the problems of the human heart in conflict with itself.'"

Foreword by Robert Cantwell

Afterword by Lawrance Thompson